

The Demand Signal

Interest is free, which is why everybody has it. A signal is something that cost the other person something. This is how to design one, run it, and read the result without flattering yourself.



Two weeks per test · Run one at a time

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If it cost them nothing, it told you nothing.

Every demand signal can be ranked by one question: what did the person give up to produce it? A click costs a second. A phone number costs a little privacy. A deposit costs money and the embarrassment of asking for it back. The ranking is the whole method.

COSTS THEM MOST

They paid, before it existed

The strongest signal available to anyone. A small amount taken seriously beats a large amount promised.

They came back, unprompted

Return without a reminder. Almost impossible to manufacture, which is why it counts.

They did work for you

Filled a long form, gave you data, brought a colleague. Effort is a currency.

They gave a way to be reached

A phone number or a real email. Costs a little, and is checkable.

They said yes to a question

Free to give, pleasant to say, and predicts almost nothing.

They clicked, or liked it

A measure of your headline, not of your product.

COSTS THEM NOTHING

Signals, ranked by what they cost the person giving them. Read your own evidence against this ladder before you put it in an application — a reader will.

This ranking is also the reason a waiting list of two thousand can be worth less than eleven people who paid. Programmes and investors have seen enough of both to price them correctly, and describing the waiting list as traction in front of someone who knows the difference costs you more than saying nothing.

One question, one number, one decision, written first

A test you designed after seeing the result is not a test. Write the four lines below before you run anything, and keep the paper. The discipline is not bureaucratic — it is the only defence against reading a disappointing result as an encouraging one.

01 The question

One sentence, answerable yes or no. “Will people in this building pay 50 EGP for this to be done on a Friday?”

02 The number that answers it

Decide what you will count. Not three numbers — one.

03 The threshold, decided now

The value above which you continue and below which you stop. Write the actual number before you start.

04 What you will do either way

Both branches, written down. If both branches say “keep going”, you have not designed a test.

Worksheet 1 · Test design

FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU RUN ANYTHING

Sign and date it. Yes, really — a dated page is much harder to quietly revise once the result is in.

The question, answerable yes or no

The one number I will count

How many people will be given the chance

The denominator. A result with no denominator is not a rate.

My threshold — at or above this I continue

What I do if it comes in below

Be specific. “Rethink” is not an action.

Date and signature

How big should the threshold be?

For a first test with ten to thirty people, pick a number that would surprise a sceptical friend. Small samples cannot detect small effects, so a threshold of “one or two” tells you nothing you did not already believe. If the honest threshold is small, run the test on more people.

Each costs the person something different

Test 01

The pre-order

Ask for a small payment now for delivery later. Refund anyone who asks, immediately and without friction.

Test 02

The manual offer

Offer to do it by hand this week, at a price. Counts how many say yes and then actually turn up.

Test 03

The reachable list

Collect phone numbers, then call them. The signal is not the sign-up — it is who answers.

Test 04

The unprompted return

Stop all reminders for two weeks. Count who comes back on their own.

Run one at a time. Two tests in one fortnight produce a result you cannot attribute to either.

Four tests, ranked by cost to the participant. All four can be run with no product, no company and no budget beyond your own time.

On taking money before you can deliver

It is the strongest signal and it carries a real obligation. Take small amounts, say plainly what they are buying and when, refund instantly on request, and keep a record of every payment and every refund. A test that leaves somebody out of pocket is not a test, it is a debt.

Rates, not counts — and the denominator in the same sentence

“Thirty people signed up” is not a result. Thirty out of forty is a strong result; thirty out of four thousand is a weak one; and the sentence is identical until the denominator is in it. Write every number as a fraction, always, including in your own notes.

SAY THIS

11 of 34 people paid a 50 EGP deposit

6 of 10 came back in a fortnight with no reminder

Median cost they described: 4 hours a week

3 of 20 asked to pay before I offered a price

NEVER SAY THIS

Strong early traction

Great feedback from users

Significant interest from the market

Validated demand

The left column is checkable and the right column is not. A reader who sees the right column assumes the left column would have been worse, because a founder with good numbers prints the numbers.

Worksheet 2 · The result

AFTER THE TEST

The number, as a fraction, with the denominator

My threshold was

Copy it from Worksheet 1 without looking at the result first.

Above or below?

What I said I would do in that case

What I am actually going to do — and if it differs, why

Differing is allowed. Differing without writing down why is how founders fool themselves.

Three ways a result lies

01 You asked people who like you

Friends, family and classmates will say yes to almost anything. Their yes is affection, correctly measured. Run the test again on strangers.

02 You changed the offer halfway

Dropping the price or adding a feature mid-test means the number at the end answers a question you never asked. Start again.

03 You counted the enthusiastic and forgot the silent

Everyone who was given the chance belongs in the denominator, including the people who ignored you. Especially those.



Where this sits. Missions 13 and 14. One designed test with a written threshold answers Mission 14 better than any self-assessment of fit.

Fit is not a score you give yourself. It is a set of numbers with denominators, taken from tests you designed before you saw the results. Keep the signed worksheets — they are the most credible part of an early application.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH **Where you actually stand**

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS **Fifteen structured missions**

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF **A verifiable credential**

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

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Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.